

manufacturing locations for pharmaceuticals in India. The pharma industry has emerged as a major component in the industrial development with over 124 registered units employing approximately 18,000 people. According to the Economic Survey of Goa 2007-08, the secondary sector (mainly manufacturing) has pushed up its contribution to the GSDP to 43 per cent in 2005-06 from 29 per cent in 1990-91.

However, Goa's mining industry does remain a cause of concern to many as Goa accounts for more than 30 per cent of India's iron-ore exports. According to export figures from 2008, Goa exports 40 million tonnes of iron ore each year. Given that most of the mining companies are small local operators, very little attention is paid to the impact on environment after the mining companies are done with extraction. On an average, for every one tonne of iron ore mined, three tonnes of soil is wasted.

by Mallini Bhupta

SIKKIM TIMES



SIKKIM

SMALL WONDER

• Stands out in Education in small states

Sikkim is a small state with big dreams. It has set a target to become a poverty-free, illiteracy-free, disease-free, zero-unemployment state by 2015. The challenges are tough and the target date is just a few years away. But the state Government is optimistic. Chief Minister Pawan Chamling has been able to think out the limitations that geography has placed on the economic capabilities of the mountain state. That the people entrust their progress to him is amply proved by the electoral mandate they have given him for four consecutive terms.

There was a time when Sikkim, a late entry into the Indian planning system, suffered from a lack of skilled workforce. Education became the watchword. When Chamling first took office in 1994, the literacy rate was 56 per cent. Today it is 82 per cent. Every village now has a school within walking distance. The focus has changed now to quality education. "We have set a target to make our teaching community 100 per cent trained by 2015," says Chamling. The annual budgetary support to education this year has been increased from 15 per cent to 20 per cent.

Road blocks in the ambitious drive to 2015

could arise because Sikkim has limited revenue generating avenues. But the state uses the funds available to it judiciously. "In spite of certain constraints unique to hilly state like our disadvantage as a landlocked state, we still utilise 99 per cent of the Central development grants," says Chamling. This shows. Sikkim has been declared a fully electrified state, a big contrast to geographically similar Darjeeling district across the Rangit and Teesta rivers. The road network in Sikkim is also the envy of most states. It has 1,747 km of roads, of which just 178 km constitute state highways. That means that a vast portion of the new roads crisscross the interiors of the state. More importantly, only 460 km are earthen, the rest are pucca black-top and macadam stretches. Sikkim is also well on its way to tap the 8,000 MW potential of its swift mountain streams. The state is targeting revenues of Rs 1,000 crore every year from sale of electricity.

The metaphor for change in Sikkim couldn't have a more telling example than the main street, the Mahatma Gandhi Road, in Gangtok, the state capital. Once a thoroughfare choked with vehicles and commercial activity, it is today a splendid, tiled promenade where tourists walk around listening to channelled music. "I have to fulfil the hopes and aspirations of the people," says Chamling, who is being helped by the Government of Singapore on town development and a Swiss university don on rural projects. Singapore's urban nuances and Switzerland's rustic impetus—these form the core of Sikkim's vision.

by Joel Rai

EVERY VILLAGE IN SIKKIM NOW HAS A SCHOOL WITHIN WALKING DISTANCE